

New Parent Exhaustion — Action Checklist

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RECOGNIZE BIOLOGY'S EFFECTS

- ☐ **Label intrusive parenting thoughts as symptoms of sleep deprivation and remind yourself that the impaired prefrontal cortex produces harsh self-criticism that is not an accurate assessment of your parenting ability.:** Label intrusive parenting thoughts as symptoms of sleep deprivation and remind yourself that the impaired prefrontal cortex produces harsh self-criticism that is not an accurate assessment of your parenting ability.
- ☐ **Recognize that your amygdala becomes more reactive during severe sleep deprivation, which explains why ordinary situations feel urgent and overwhelming—this is biology, not personal failure or weakness.:** Recognize that your amygdala becomes more reactive during severe sleep deprivation, which explains why ordinary situations feel urgent and overwhelming—this is biology, not personal failure or weakness.
- ☐ **Acknowledge that impaired cortisol regulation from sleep loss makes your stress response harder to shut off, so the persistent tension and anxiety you feel has a measurable biological cause rather than being purely emotional.:** Acknowledge that impaired cortisol regulation from sleep loss makes your stress response harder to shut off, so the persistent tension and anxiety you feel has a measurable biological cause rather than being purely emotional.
- ☐ **Understand that memory and language processing slow down significantly when sleep deprived, which is why you walk into rooms and forget why or struggle to find words—this is not early dementia or losing your mind.:** Understand that memory and language processing slow down significantly when sleep deprived, which is why you walk into rooms and forget why or struggle to find words—this is not early dementia or losing your mind.

PRACTICE QUICK RECOVERY

- ☐ **Practice the Physiological Sigh whenever you feel overwhelmed:** inhale deeply through your nose, take a second short inhale, then exhale slowly through your mouth, and repeat this three times to shift your nervous system out of fight-or-flight mode.
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- **Use the 20-Minute Rule by committing to do only ONE restorative activity in each brief window when your baby sleeps—choose from eating a real meal, showering, stepping outside, lying on the floor, or calling a supportive person.:** Use the 20-Minute Rule by committing to do only ONE restorative activity in each brief window when your baby sleeps—choose from eating a real meal, showering, stepping outside, lying on the floor, or calling a supportive person.
- **Try the Physiological Sigh right now even if you are not currently in crisis, to establish the habit so it is available to you when acute stress or panic actually hits during the difficult weeks ahead.:** Try the Physiological Sigh right now even if you are not currently in crisis, to establish the habit so it is available to you when acute stress or panic actually hits during the difficult weeks ahead.
- **Apply the 5-7-3 breathing pattern during overwhelming moments:** exhale for 7 seconds, hold for 5 seconds, inhale for 3 seconds, and repeat this cycle 3 to 5 times to activate your parasympathetic response.

BUILD YOUR SUPPORT SYSTEM

- **Identify and write down three specific support people by name before you actually need help, so you have concrete contacts ready to call when exhaustion becomes unbearable rather than scrambling in the moment.:** Identify and write down three specific support people by name before you actually need help, so you have concrete contacts ready to call when exhaustion becomes unbearable rather than scrambling in the moment.
- **Call at least one person who makes you feel like yourself during a 20-minute window, because social connection deposits something back into your depleted reserves that no amount of solo rest can replace.:** Call at least one person who makes you feel like yourself during a 20-minute window, because social connection deposits something back into your depleted reserves that no amount of solo rest can replace.
- **Accept help when it is offered even if the specific task is not your top priority, because imperfect assistance is still better than managing everything alone while running on empty.:** Accept help when it is offered even if the specific task is not your top priority, because imperfect assistance is still better than managing everything alone while running on empty.
- **Create a written list of your three support people with their contact information and preferred times to be reached, posting it somewhere visible so it is easy to access when your cognitive function is most impaired.:** Create a written list of your three support people with their contact information and preferred times to be reached, posting it somewhere visible so it is easy to access when your cognitive function is most impaired.

Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.